NEW MINOR FORCING

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

Although it is not a part of the Deals you might wish to examine your and dummy's hand and make a Plan of how you would play the contract.

NEW MINOR FORCING SUMMARY

In standard bidding a new suit by Responder at his second turn is forcing for one round, **EXCEPT** when Opener's rebid was 1NT.

Pard	You		Pard	You
1♦	1♠	or	1♣	1♥
1NT	2♥		1NT	2♦

Your second bid is not forcing and partner is expected to either pass or give preference back to your first suit.
For the first example your hand might be:

♠ Q J 9 8 5 ♥ K J 7 4 ♦ 7 3 ♣ 4 2

That is just fine when you do have a weak hand. But consider this:

Pard	You
1♦	1♠
1NT	???

♠ A K 9 8 5 ♥ K 9 7 ♦ 7 3 ♣ A 10 9

With 14 points you know you must get to game somewhere. You could just jump to 3NT but if you did so and partner turned out to have a 3-card ♠ support you might go down at 3NT when 4♠ was a laydown.

What you need is a bid that will force partner to bid again, and to give you some more information about his hand as he does so. And thus was New Minor Forcing created.

> Following a 1NT rebid by Opener, Responder's bid of a previously unbid minor suit is artificial and forcing. Opener is requested to further describe his hand.

There are exactly six possibilities:

Pard	You
1♣	1♥
1NT	2♦

Pard	You
1♦	1♥
1NT	2♣

Pard	You
1♥	1♠
1NT	2♣

Pard	You
1♣	1♠
1NT	2♦

Pard	You
1♦	1♠
1NT	2♣

Pard	You
1♥	1♠
1NT	2♦

In all these cases your second bid of 2♣ or 2♦ is forcing.

But in these sequences,

Pard	You
1♣	1♠
1NT	2♥

Pard	You
1♦	1♠
1NT	2♥

your 2♥ bid is not forcing because it isn't a minor.

Requirements for New Minor Forcing:

The first requirement is a little caution.
Partner's 1NT rebid has put his hand at 12-14 points. Perhaps he could have a 15 point hand that for some reason he couldn't open 1NT, but that is stretching his bid. So you need to have a hand that is good enough to force him to bid again. Some partnerships insist on an opening hand for you, but most play that a good 11 points should be the minimum strength.

And of course you should also have the type of hand that can't be described by a natural bid.

Assume this bidding sequence for the examples below:

Pard	You
1♣	1♠
1NT	2♦

♠ A K 7 5 2 ♥ K 9 3 ♦ 10 9 ♣ K 6 4
You know you want to be in game but are unsure whether 3NT or 4♠ is best.
So you bid 2♦ (NMF) to force partner to bid again.

♠ K Q 8 7 3 ♥ A Q J 6 ♦ 8 2 ♣ 6 4
You can't bid 2♥ because partner would pass and you know you should be in game.
A jump to 3♥ shows a 5-card suit.
Again, the solution is to bid 2♦ which partner cannot pass.

Opener's third bid:

Opener's first two bids have already described his hand very well, so there isn't much more to be said. But Responder has asked for more information, so Opener bids again with the following priorities:

1. Show a 4-card ♥ suit.
2. Show 3-card support for Responder's first suit.
3. Bid notrump with stoppers in the unbid suits.

4. Raise partner's "new minor suit" with at least 4 card support.
5. Rebid your 5-card minor suit if no other bid is possible.

Opener may also be able to say something about his strength. Since the hand is somewhere in the 12-15 point range he can make a minimum bid with 12-13 and jump with 14-15. This is strictly a partnership thing, if you don't want to incorporate it then NMF will work just fine without it.

Assume this bidding sequence for the examples below:

You	**Pard**
1♦	1♠
1NT	2♣
??	

♠ 6 4 ♥ K 9 7 4 ♦ K Q J 5 ♣ A 10 3
Bid 2♥. This is your top priority.

♠ 10 6 4 ♥ A 9 ♦ K Q 10 6 5 ♣ Q 10 3
Bid 2♠. This shows 3 cards in the suit.

♠ A 6 4 ♥ 10 9 6 ♦ K Q J 6 ♣ A 8 3
Bid 3♠. This shows 3 cards, but with maximum strength.

♠ 6 4 ♥ A Q 6 ♦ K Q J 9 6 ♣ 10 8 3
Bid 2NT. This shows a ♥ stopper, but fewer than 3 ♠s.

♠ 6 4 ♥ 10 8 3 ♦ A K Q 9 ♣ A 10 8 3
Bid 3♣. This shows 4 ♣s, fewer than 3 ♠s and an unwillingness to play notrump (no ♥ stopper).

♠ 6 4 ♥ 10 8 3 ♦ A K J 9 4 ♣ A 10 3
Bid 2♦. You hate to rebid a 5-card suit but partner has forced you to bid and none of the other choices are possible.

New Minor Forcing after 2NT:

If Opener's second bid is a jump to 2NT that shows a balanced 18-19 point hand. Responder can use New Minor Forcing to find the best contract.

Assume this bidding sequence for the examples below:

Pard	**You**
1♣	1♠
2NT	3♦

♠ K Q 10 5 2 ♥ 9 6 3 ♦ A 8 4 ♣ 5 2
You know you want to be in game but are unsure whether 3NT or 4♠ is best.
So you bid 3♦ (NMF) to force partner to bid again.

♠ K Q J 7 3 ♥ A ♦ K Q 2 ♣ 10 7 6 4
You are probably going to bid a slam, either 6NT or 6♠.
Bid 3♦ to ask partner if he has 3 ♠s.

And then what?

And then it's up to you. New Minor Forcing is complete after those two bids. From that point one of the partners, probably Responder, should be able to choose a contract. All subsequent bidding is just your normal bidding system.

If the opponents interfere you should play that NMF is off and all bids have natural meanings.

14 examples will be worth more than another 14000 words.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥8

Board: 2
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥5

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦6

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥8

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ 7 2 ♥ K Q 7 5 ♦ J 9 6 ♣ A K 9 4	
♠ A 9 4 ♥ 10 9 6 4 ♦ A 8 4 3 ♣ J 6		♠ 8 6 3 ♥ J 8 2 ♦ Q 5 2 ♣ Q 7 5 2
	♠ K Q J 10 5 ♥ A 3 ♦ K 10 7 ♣ 10 8 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	Pass	1♠
Pass	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥8

You have 14 points and you respond 1♠. Partner rebids 1NT. What is your next bid?

Partner has 12-14 points, balanced. You will insist on reaching game, but don't know whether 3NT or 4♠ is going to be the best spot. It depends on whether partner has 3 ♠s. So of course you use NMF.

You bid 2♦ and partner then says 2♥. Where do you go from here?

OK, partner has a 4-card ♥ suit - may or may not have 3 ♠s. Since you don't have 4 ♥s you bid 3NT, leaving it up to partner to correct to 4♠ if he has 3 of them.

Board 2
West Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 8 5 ♥ K 9 8 6 2 ♦ 8 7 4 2 ♣ 8 2	
♠ A 10 7 ♥ A J 10 ♦ K J 5 ♣ K Q 10 6	N W E S	♠ K Q 9 6 2 ♥ Q 7 4 ♦ Q 9 3 ♣ 9 3
	♠ J 4 3 ♥ 5 3 ♦ A 10 6 ♣ A J 7 5 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♣	Pass	1♠	Pass
2NT	Pass	3♦	Pass
3♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♥5

You are too strong for 1NT so you open 1♣. Partner responds 1♠.

You don't support ♠s with only 3 cards since partner might well have just a 4-card suit. With 18 points, balanced, all suits stopped, you jump to 2NT.

Partner says 3♦.

This is New Minor Forcing. Partner wants to know if you have 3 ♠s. Since you do have 3 you bid 3♠ and partner raises to 4♠.

Board 3
South Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ K Q 10 5 3 ♥ 7 3 ♦ A 5 3 ♣ A Q 3	
♠ A 8 7 6 2 ♥ 9 4 ♦ 8 6 2 ♣ J 6 2	N W E S	♠ 9 ♥ J 10 5 2 ♦ J 10 9 7 ♣ 9 8 7 5
	♠ J 4 ♥ A K Q 8 6 ♦ K Q 4 ♣ K 10 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
Pass	1♠	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3NT
Pass	6NT		
All Pass			

6NT by South
Lead: ♦6

You have 16 points and you respond 1♠. Partner rebids 2NT. What is your next bid?

Partner has 18-19 points, balanced, with 5 ♥s. You are going to bid a slam, either 6NT or 6♠, depending on whether partner has 3 ♠s. Time for New Minor Forcing.

You bid 3♣ rather than 3♦ just because your ♣s are stronger. Partner now says 3NT.

Partner does not have 3 ♠s. That was the information you needed, so you bid 6NT.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 5 3 ♥ 10 8 4 ♦ 10 5 3 2 ♣ A 8 3 2	
♠ K 8 ♥ 9 6 2 ♦ A K Q 8 4 ♣ 10 9 6		♠ A Q 6 4 2 ♥ K Q 7 ♦ J 6 ♣ Q J 4
	♠ J 10 9 7 ♥ A J 5 3 ♦ 9 7 ♣ K 7 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♦	Pass	1♠	Pass
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♦	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♥8

You have 13 points and you open 1♦. Partner responds 1♠.

With a minimum opener you now bid 1NT. Partner says 2♣. What do you say next?

This is NMF, asking you to further describe your hand - and you are stuck for a bid. You do not have 4 ♥s. You do not have 3 ♠s. You do not have a stopper in either ♥s or ♣s so you cannot bid 2NT. Reluctantly you rebid your 5-card ♦ suit.

Then you breathe a sigh of relief when partner says 3NT.